

Cananga odorata syn. *Canangium odoratum* (Annonaceae)

Ylang-Ylang

Description Evergreen tree growing to 80 ft (25 m). Has lance-shaped leaves and strongly scented yellow-green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Indonesia and the Philippines, ylang-ylang is cultivated in tropical Asia and Africa.

Parts Used Flowers, essential oil.

Constituents The essential oil contains linalool (11–30%), safrole, eugenol, geraniol, and sesquiterpenes (including 15–25% germacrene).

History & Folklore The flowers are a traditional adornment in the Far East. Their scent is thought to have aphrodisiac qualities.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The flowers and essential oil are sedative, antimicrobial, and antioxidant. The oil has a soothing effect, and its main therapeutic uses are to slow an excessively fast heart rate and to lower blood pressure. With its reputation as an aphrodisiac, ylang-ylang may be helpful in treating impotence.

⚠ **Caution** Do not take the essential oil internally without professional supervision.

Canella winterana syn. *C. alba* (Canellaceae)

Canella, Wild Cinnamon

Description White-barked tree growing to 49 ft (15 m). Has elliptical leaves, red flowers, and purple-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Caribbean and Florida, canella is found in coastal swamps and scrubland. The bark is collected by gently beating the branches.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Canella contains about 1% volatile oil (including eugenol, alpha-pinene, and caryophyllene), alpha-aldehydes (including canellal), resin, and mannitol.

History & Folklore Canella has for a long time been used as a flavoring for tobacco (*Nicotiana tabacum*, p. 240).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Canella is cytotoxic (kills cells), antifungal, and repels insects. It is also aromatic, stimulant, and antiseptic. Canella is often used in the West Indies and Latin America as a substitute for cinnamon (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81). The infusion is drunk for its pleasant flavor and tonic effect (the bark is considered a sexual stimulant). Canella is also used for stomach problems and indigestion.

Cannabis sativa (Cannabinaceae)
Marijuana,
Huo Ma Ren (Chinese)

Description Erect, branching annual growing to 13 ft (4 m). Has fine, serrated, segmented leaves. Both male and female plants flower; the female plant produces seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Caucasus, China, Iran, and northern India, marijuana is cultivated the world over; both legally (for the fiber and seeds) and illegally (for use as a recreational drug).

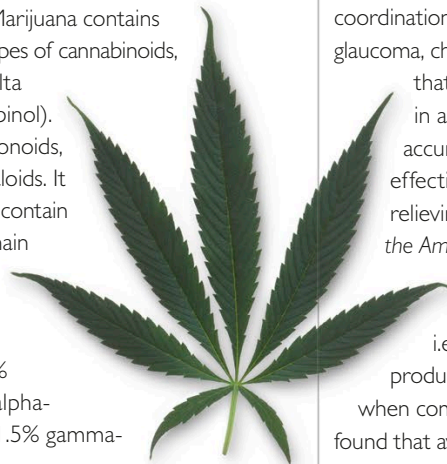
Parts Used Flowering tops of female plants, seeds.

Constituents Marijuana contains over 60 different types of cannabinoids, including THC (delta 9-tetrahydrocannabinol). It also contains flavonoids, volatile oil, and alkaloids. It is the only plant to contain THC, one of the main psychoactive constituents. The seed oil contains approximately 55% linoleic acid, 20% alpha-linolenic acid and 1.5% gamma-linolenic acid.

History & Folklore

In ancient Egypt, marijuana was used to treat inflammations of the eye and “to cool the uterus.” First records of marijuana’s use in India date back to about 800 BCE, where it is recommended for congestion. Famously, Queen Victoria took marijuana as an analgesic—in the 19th century the plant was a standard painkiller for menstrual pain and cramps. From 1840 to 1900, over 100 papers were published recommending marijuana as a medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In view of its long history as a medicinal treatment, it is hardly surprising that marijuana has, at one time or another, been recommended for almost every illness. As an analgesic, it appears to relieve pain with minimal side effects, being particularly helpful for cancer and AIDS patients undergoing chemotherapy. For those suffering from multiple sclerosis, cerebral palsy, and other muscular illnesses, marijuana can reduce neurological overactivity and muscle spasm. The plant provides effective treatment for glaucoma, in which pressure within the eye is abnormally high, and is hypotensive, lowering blood pressure. Marijuana relieves asthma, menstrual pains, the pain of childbirth, and of arthritis and rheumatism, and may have value as an antidepressant. It encourages and induces sleep. The seeds are used in Chinese medicine as a strong but well-tolerated laxative, especially for constipation in the elderly; and as a



Marijuana leaf

dietary supplement to provide a balanced and healthy supply of polyunsaturated fatty acids.

Research Modern research shows marijuana to be a sedative, an anti-inflammatory agent, and an analgesic as effective as codeine. Research has focused on the constituent THC, but it is clear that the complex of constituents within marijuana has a significantly wider range of applications. Clinical studies from 1975 onwards have shown that the cannabinoids are powerfully antiemetic, especially in those having chemotherapy. To varying degrees, clinical trials indicate that marijuana or its cannabinoids relieves symptoms in multiple sclerosis (such as tremor, muscle spasm, and poor coordination), in spinal cord injuries, epilepsy, glaucoma, chronic pain, and loss of appetite. Now that medical marijuana is legally available in a number of U.S. states, there is accumulating evidence of just how effective the herb, and extracts of it, are in relieving pain. A 2015 article in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* found “30% or greater improvement in pain with cannabinoid compared to placebo,” i.e., marijuana extracts on average produced a 30% or more improvement when compared to an inert substance. It also found that availability of medical-grade marijuana was associated “with a 15–35% decrease in substance abuse admissions.” Not only is medical marijuana a valuable analgesic, it also helps to prevent addiction to other painkillers, in particular opioids, such as codeine and morphine.

Caution Marijuana is a controlled substance in North America. Research your local laws.

Capparis spinosa (Capparaceae)
Caper

Description Shrub growing to 3 ft (1 m), with spiny trailing stems, fleshy oval leaves, green buds, large white flowers, and red berries in autumn.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean region, caper thrives in open areas, often growing on stony terrain. The buds are harvested before the flowers open and are pickled for culinary use.

Parts Used Root bark, bark, flower buds.

Constituents Contains phenolic compounds.

History & Folklore Though much favored as a piquant food by the ancient Greeks, capers were said to disagree with the stomach. They remain a popular condiment to this day.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The unopened flower buds are laxative and, if prepared correctly with vinegar, are thought to ease stomach pain. The bark is bitter and diuretic and can be taken immediately before meals to increase the appetite.